

WWI FIGHTERS

THE SPECIALIZATION OF MILITARY AIRCRAFT brought the emergence of the fighting “scout” from early in the war. The earliest effective fighters, the French Morane-Saulnier and the German Fokker Eindecker, were flimsy monoplanes which used outdated wing-warping, but benefitted from guns firing forward through a tractor propeller. The British still maintained an attachment to pusher propellers on aircraft with a forward-firing gun, in the one-seater Airco D.H.2 and the two-seater Vickers Gunbus. Tractor propellers gave superior performance, however, and by 1917, various single-seat tractor biplanes predominated. The two broad groups were fast machines with inline engines – like the SPAD XIII – which excelled at diving attacks and pursuit, and more maneuverable machines with rotary engines, such as the Nieuport 17 and Sopwith Camel. These were difficult to fly but in a dogfight they could turn on a dime. Most maneuverable of all were the rotary-engined triplanes such as the Fokker Dr.I. Probably the finest all-around fighter of the war was the inline-engined Fokker D.VII (see pages 88–9), introduced in 1918.

BRISTOL F.2B

Another late-war success story was the Bristol F.2B, which reintroduced the two-seat fighter concept. See pages 76–77.



Airco D.H.2



Introduced in 1915, the D.H.2 could only mount a forward firing gun by fitting a pusher engine. Being a single-seater, it was fast enough to keep up with its prey, although the pilot had to control the aircraft and fire at the same time, making it hard to fly.

ENGINE 100hp Gnome Monosoupape 9-cylinder rotary

WINGSPAN 28ft 3in (8.6m) **LENGTH** 25ft 2in (7.7m)

TOP SPEED 93mph (150kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x .303in Lewis machine gun

Albatros D.III

The Albatros D series was part of the German effort to recover air superiority in 1917 after the eclipse of the Fokker E.III. During “Bloody April,” the D.III inflicted heavy casualties on the RFC. However the improved D.V was still inferior to the SPAD and RAF SE.5a.



ENGINE 170hp Mercedes D.IIIa 6-cylinder water-cooled

WINGSPAN 29ft 8in (9.1m) **LENGTH** 24ft (7.3m)

TOP SPEED 109mph (175kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 2 x 7.92mm Spandau machine guns

Brandenburg D.I



Designed in Germany by Ernst Heinkel, the D.I was built in Austria and entered service with the Austrian Air Force in the fall of 1916. However, poor flight characteristics and limited visibility caused a number of accidents, leading to its pilot nickname, “The Coffin.”

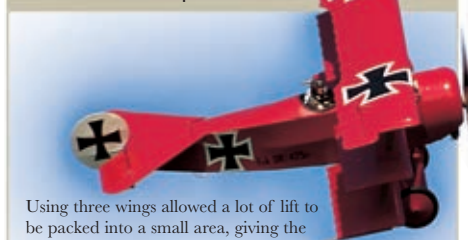
ENGINE 160hp Austro-Daimler 6-cylinder liquid-cooled inline

WINGSPAN 27ft 11in (8.5m) **LENGTH** 20ft 10in (6.4m)

TOP SPEED 116mph (187kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 8mm Schwarzlose machine gun

Fokker Dr.I triplane



Using three wings allowed a lot of lift to be packed into a small area, giving the Fokker Dr.I a fast rate of climb and good maneuverability, which made it ideal for air fighting. During late 1917, it was feared along the Western Front, most famously in the hands of Manfred von Richthofen.

ENGINE 110hp Le Rhone 9-cylinder rotary

WINGSPAN 23ft 7in (7.2m) **LENGTH** 18ft 11in (5.8m)

TOP SPEED 103mph (165kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 2 x 7.92mm Spandau machine guns

Fokker E.III Eindecker

Equipped with a machine gun and an interrupter gear that allowed it to fire through the propeller, Anthony Fokker's prewar monoplane design became the deadly E.III (replica shown), which cut a swathe through Allied observation aircraft in the summer of 1915. This was mainly due to its innovative armament and the brilliance of its pilots, including Boelcke and Immelmann.



ENGINE 100hp Oberursel 7-cylinder rotary

WINGSPAN 31ft 3in (9.5m) **LENGTH** 23ft 7in (7.2m)

TOP SPEED 81mph (130kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 7.92mm Spandau machine gun